



UNDER SCRUTINY: Yohannan (extreme left), Bhadrananda (top), and foreign currency seized from the Thankus

estates, schools and theological colleges in the state and is said to receive Rs 200 crore as contributions from outside the country, ostensibly for his charitable work. As per Home Ministry's annual report on organisations receiving foreign contributions, Yohannan's organisations received more than Rs 130 crore in 2005-06 while Mata Amritanandamayi Mutt received Rs 85.33 crore. Both Yohannan and the Amritanandamayi Mutt have come out with statements saying their dealings have been above board. "Fake godmen and women have to be booked. But all the spiritual organisations should not be painted with the same brush," says Swami Amritanandamayi Puri, second in command of Mata Amritanandamayi Mutt.

Another dramatic incident revolved around the arrest of Swami Himaval Maheswarananda Bhadrananda after the media reported that he was going around in a car fitted with a red beacon light reserved for ministers, police or ambulances. When he was brought to the police station, Swami pulled out a pistol and threatened to kill himself in front of the policemen and television

incident. The revenue official who had granted the arms licence to Bhadrananda has been suspended.

Another religious group under investigation by the Income Tax Department is the Heavenly Feast group, high-profile evangelists who offer divine healing to devotees suffering from terminal diseases. A district medical officer who had publicly 'confirmed' that some cancer patients were cured after attending the Heavenly Feast function has since been suspended from service. The two Pastors—the Thanku brothers—have stopped making personal appearances on the Heavenly Feast show since.

Politicians have now got into the act with BJP and many Hindu religious organisations questioning CPI(M)'s motives, dubbing the drive as the atheists' onslaught on faith, god and religion. They also charge that the Government is mainly after Hindu organisations. The issue has also triggered communal divisions as RSS and Shiv Sena have targeted the offices of Christian and Muslim organisations and released a

"We have launched a drive to investigate these so-called spiritual leaders."

KODIYERI BALAKRISHNAN, STATE HOME MINISTER

cameras present. When the media tried to talk to him, the godman abused them and in the melee, the pistol went off. While in custody, Bhadrananda bragged about his links with many politicians, including CPI(M) Politburo member and state Home Minister Balakrishnan. "Once I predicted to Balettan (elder brother) that he would become a Politburo member. It came true in the last CPI(M) congress. Once I told Achu Chandy (daughter of former chief minister Oommen Chandy) that her father should watch his step. Didn't he fall down and break his leg while he was visiting Davos?" asked the unbalanced godman.

Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan was not amused. "It was a shame that the police simply sat and watched him while he was armed with a pistol," he said, and ordered a probe into the

list of Communist and Congress leaders who had visited many ashrams of godmen and women who are now under the scanner.

They have forgotten what the Bible says about those who cast the first stone. Top BJP leader and former Union minister O. Rajagopal was a regular at an ashram of one of the 'tainted' godwomen, who now faces charges of cheating and fraud. "I am a believer and visit many ashrams. How could I know this ashram had such a background?" says Rajagopal. The party has now issued a circular warning partymen to be more circumspect in dealings with godmen and women. It is a circular that should have been first issued to the thousands of gullible disciples and celebrities who made sure that spiritualism became a cover for sinning. ■